I wasn’t fazed by the more important concerts, or the pomp and ceremony of certain services. I was the workhorse, the guy who rarely took solos, never got ill and sang consistently to an acceptable standard, all good preparation for professional sport, where coaches love the player they can rely on, rock solid without being exceptional.

Management specialists love to talk about success leaving clues, and it is certainly true that talent has a traceable timeline. Mum remembers me pestering her with a soft ball when I was not much older than two. She’d break off from the washing-up and throw it at me across the kitchen, with the promise I’d get a biscuit if I caught it at the furthest point in the room.

It was only later that I realized she would throw it that little bit harder when the treat was due. I wasn’t deterred. I would sit on the floor of my bedroom, with my head resting against the side of the mattress, throwing and catching the ball off the ceiling, walls and furniture. I was unconsciously developing hand–eye co-ordination.

We rehashed countless snooker World Championships in the kitchen, on a table measuring two feet by four feet, propped up by stools. Before I went up to St Paul’s the family would play tennis or badminton in the village hall three times a week. A combination of nature and nurture was involved across disciplines.

Musically, my parents were talented. They used to sing in the church choir at Wickham Bishops, and I had learned to read music by the time I was six. My paternal grandad was a very, very good violinist and would make instruments for my brothers. I specialized in the clarinet and saxophone but couldn’t consistently play by ear.

That’s an incredible skill; even now, the only piano piece I can play without a music score in front of me is the intro to ‘Crazy Little Thing Called Love’, by Queen. I’m a diligent learner, though. If I were to practise daily for a week, I could probably get the whole song off pat. As for my angelic singing, it went south when my voice broke at the age of sixteen. It’s difficult to retrain.

There is an ethereal quality to the best choirs, a natural ease and beauty. I’m not sure you can say the same about my batting, though I do consider myself a natural batsman in that I am largely self-taught. In the choir I read the notes; at the crease I watch the ball. I have scored runs at every level because I have an ability to play every ball on its merits, no matter how